

ESSENTIAL

Schengen Tourist Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - the Verpflichtungserklärung, process, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Schengen Tourist Visa is - and isn't

A Type C visa issued by a German mission lets you travel across the Schengen area for tourism, visiting family or friends, or short business activities, for up to 90 days within any 180-day period. It's decided under the shared EU Visa Code, by the German Foreign Office (Auswärtiges Amt) through its embassies and consulates - Germany doesn't run a separate national short-stay visa; this is the standard uniform Schengen visa, applied for through Germany specifically.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Confirm Germany is the right consulate	Based on your main destination or first point of entry, if visiting multiple Schengen countries.
2. Arrange your Verpflichtungserklärung, if applicable	Your host obtains this in person at their local Ausländerbehörde - start this early.
3. Book your appointment	Often through an outsourced application centre (VFS Global/TLScontact) - availability varies significantly by location and season.
4. Buy travel medical insurance	Meeting the Schengen minimum coverage.
5. Attend your appointment	Submit documents and give biometrics.
6. Decision	Standard processing is commonly around 15 calendar days, though this can extend in specific cases - check current timelines with your specific mission.
7. Get your visa	A visa sticker (vignette) is affixed to your passport if approved.

The Verpflichtungserklärung, explained properly

This is a formally binding declaration of commitment, obtained by the host - not the applicant - at their own local Ausländerbehörde in Germany. By signing it, the host takes on financial responsibility for the visitor's stay, including costs the state might otherwise bear. It's a genuinely different mechanism from a simple invitation letter, and it takes real lead time to arrange, since it requires an in-person process on the host's side before the applicant can even submit their visa application relying on it.

Appointment availability

Wait times for a visa appointment can vary substantially by country and season - in some locations, booking well in advance is essential. Factor this into your planning separately from the visa's own processing time once your application is actually submitted.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on a Tourist Visa?

No - short, incidental business activities (meetings, negotiations) are permitted, but general employment isn't, the same as elsewhere in the Schengen area.

What if I'm visiting Germany and another Schengen country?

Apply through whichever country's consulate is responsible under the Schengen "competent consulate" rule - generally your main destination, or first point of entry if time is split evenly.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for how the Remonstrationsverfahren and judicial review work specifically for German-issued refusals.